



BIG ON DIAGNOSTICS
India's diagnostics market is creating stronger, tech-enabled national networks to improve access

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HEAL THE WORLD

India is aiming to become a health tourism destination by 2047. This would need mastering not just drugs and vaccines but also hospital care, diagnostics, digital systems, and clinical expertise. Can it achieve the target?

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

SOME OF INDIA'S major metropolitan cities have for years provided healthcare services to patients from Africa, the Middle East, Sri Lanka, Maldives, Central Asia, Africa, Bangladesh, south-east Asia, Myanmar, Nepal, and Bhutan, among others.

While Chennai, Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Kolkata have become thriving healthcare hubs, in case of pharmaceutical manufacturing, the journey has been long. Once known as the pharmacy of the Global South, the Covid-19 pandemic provided India an opportunity to emerge as a full-fledged healthcare engine built for scale.

Two of the most widely used vaccines during the pandemic, Covishield and Covaxin, were made in India, with Serum Institute of India's Covishield earning the moniker "vaccine for the world." This built a case for India becoming

the world's healthcare powerhouse on the lines of Singapore (Asia's top medical tourism and research and development or R&D hub), South Korea (known for robotic surgery and health tech) or China (rapidly growing biotechnology and health manufacturing).

For India's healthcare sector to rise to the Viksit Bharat 2047 ambitions, it must not only expand existing healthcare services capabilities but also build manufacturing and R&D capacities. "It will take more than just exporting affordable generics. We need a balanced strategy that combines our strengths in pharmaceutical manufacturing with expanded clinical services, including doctors, hospitals, diagnostics, and digital health platforms," says Arup Mitra, Dean and Professor of Economics at South Asian University in New Delhi.

The Covid-19 pandemic acted as a catalyst for pharmaceutical manufacturing in India. Government and industry collaboration—through

| 179